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INTERNATIONAL IP DAY

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From Guild Secrets to Global Treaties: The Story of Intellectual Property Rights

The modern idea of intellectual property began in 1474 with the Venetian Patent Statute, which granted inventors exclusive rights for a limited time. This was the 1st formal recognition that innovation deserved legal protection. Later, in 1624, England's Statute of Monopolies transformed patents from royal privileges into enforceable legal rights.

By the late 19th century, industrial growth made international protection essential. The Paris Convention (1883) established cross-border protection for patents and trademarks, while the Berne Convention (1886) did the same for copyright, laying the foundation of the global IP system.

India's IP framework started under colonial rule with the Patent Law of 1856, followed by the Patents and Designs Act, 1911, which consolidated earlier laws but largely served foreign interests rather than domestic innovation.

A major shift came with the Patents Act, 1970, which removed product patents for food and pharmaceuticals. This enabled Indian companies to produce low-cost generic medicines, positioning India as the "pharmacy of the developing world."

After joining the WTO in 1995, India complied with the TRIPS Agreement by 2005, reintroducing product patents while safeguarding public health through Section 3(d). During the HIV/AIDS crisis, Cipla played a crucial role by offering life-saving antiretroviral drugs at a fraction of global prices, showing that strong IP laws can coexist with access to affordable medicines.

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Patents unlocked: how ideas become assets

“Intellectual property has the shelf life of a banana.” — Bill Gates

When Steve Jobs introduced the 1st iPhone, its multi-touch “pinch-to-zoom” feature felt revolutionary and was quickly patented by Apple. For a brief period, it gave Apple a clear competitive edge. However, competitors soon developed alternative methods to achieve similar functionality, and touch gestures rapidly became an industry standard. This reflects a core reality of IP, in fast-moving sectors, exclusivity is often short-lived. The real advantage lies not in holding a single patent, but in continuously innovating ahead of the competition.

"Intellectual property protection provides both inventors and those who commercialize ideas with an avenue to benefit from their innovation efforts." — Helen Kerr

When Pfizer developed breakthrough drugs, it invested heavily in research and trials. Patent protection gave it temporary exclusivity to recover costs and profit. Once the patent expired, generics entered the market, improving access while maintaining a balance between innovation and public benefit.

"The question today is not whether you have IP, it is whether you know how to use your IP." — Kalyan C. Kankanala

In its early days, The Walt Disney Company owned Mickey Mouse as just a cartoon figure. Instead of stopping at films, it licensed the character, expanded into merchandise, and built entire experiences around it. Over time, Mickey Mouse evolved into a global icon. This shows that the real value of IP lies not in ownership alone, but in how strategically it is used and expanded. This is exactly what Kankanala means in his quote. IP is static, like a locked treasure chest. The magic happens when you unlock it through licensing, partnerships, commercialization, and creative expansion.

"The thief flatters us by stealing. We flatter him by complaining." — Ben Hecht

In Elizabethan England, William Shakespeare’s plays were widely imitated, with rivals borrowing his plots and themes. To them, imitation was a shortcut to success. But in truth, it was a compliment: they stole because Shakespeare’s words were too powerful to ignore. Yet instead of reacting, he continued creating works that far outshone the copies. Ben Hecht’s paradox comes alive here. Shakespeare’s legacy proves that the best response to plagiarism is not outrage, but creation. Over time, his originality endured while the imitators faded, showing that true genius outlasts imitation.

Women and IP in India: A Revolution in Motion

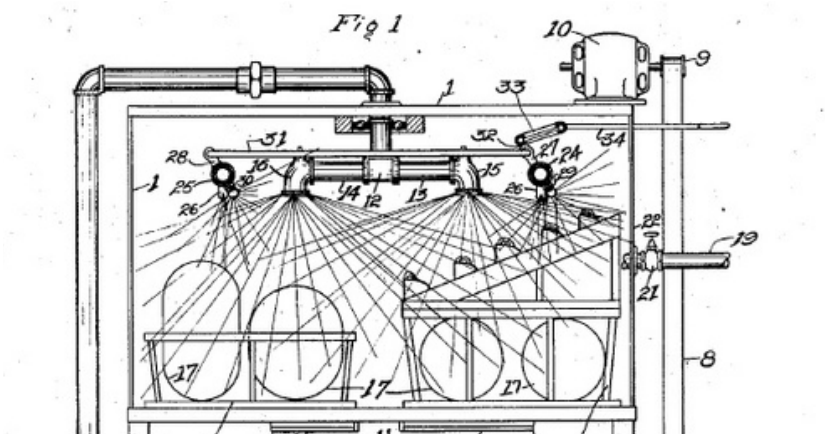
Women Enter the Story

While IP laws were taking shape, women's contributions remained largely invisible.

- In 1809, Mary Dixon Kies became the first woman in the U.S. to receive a patent, for weaving straw with silk.
- Josephine Cochrane (1886) patented the dishwasher, reshaping household labor.
- Mary Anderson (1903) patented the windshield wiper, now standard in cars.

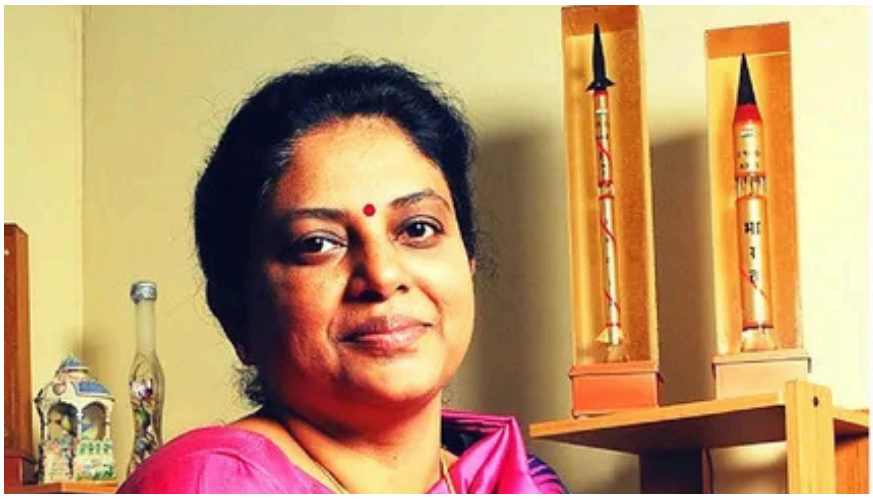
The Quiet Revolution

Across India, a quiet revolution is unfolding. Women are stepping boldly into the world of IP, transforming ideas into tangible solutions. Reports still show women account for only 13–15% of patent applicants, but behind those numbers lies a growing movement. Each new patent filed by a woman is not just an invention, but a proof that resilience and creativity are steadily reshaping India's innovation ecosystem.



Global Inspirations

- *Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw* - Starting Biocon in her garage, she transformed it into India's first major biopharmaceutical company. Her patents in enzyme technology and affordable biologics helped make critical medicines accessible, proving that persistence can rewrite the healthcare landscape.
- *Sara Blakely* - She turned a simple idea into Spanx by filing her own patent, proving that everyday problems can lead to billion-dollar innovations.
- *Whitney Wolfe Herd* - By creating Bumble, where women make the first move, she protected a unique platform idea that reshaped online dating.
- *Melanie Perkins* - After years of rejection, she built Canva and secured IP for simple design tools, making creativity accessible worldwide.
- *Falguni Nayar* - She launched Nykaa with strong trademarks and IP protections, transforming India's beauty retail space.
- *Rosalind Franklin* - Her "Photo 51" discovery revealed DNA's structure, laying the foundation for modern genetics.
- *Radha Vembu* - She grew Zoho into a global tech company by focusing on practical innovation and strong IP.



Patents with Purpose: India & the World

Indian Innovators

- *Tessy Thomas: Agni Missile Systems* - Known as the "Missile Woman of India," she played a key role in developing advanced systems in the Agni missile series, leading innovation in defence technology.

- *Geetha Manjunath: AI Breast Cancer Detection* - She patented AI-based thermal imaging technology for early breast cancer detection, improving accessibility in healthcare diagnostics.

- *Mukta Ghate Farooq: Semiconductor Innovation* - With over 250 U.S. patents, she has contributed significantly to semiconductor and chip technology shaping modern computing.

- *Remya Jose: Pedal-Powered Washing Machine* - At 14, she patented a low-cost washing machine made from bicycle parts, showing how simple ideas can solve real problems.

- *Prerana Ratnaparkhi: Foldable Shopping Bag* - Her design patent introduced a foldable bag with wheels, offering a practical solution for everyday convenience.

Global Icons

- *Tu Youyou: Artemisinin* - Her discovery of Artemisinin, patented for malaria treatment, revolutionized global healthcare and saved millions of lives.

- *Stephanie Kwolek: Kevlar* - She invented and patented Kevlar, the super-strong fiber used in bulletproof vests, helmets, and countless protective applications.

- *Grace Hopper: Computer Compiler* - Her compiler patent laid the foundation for modern programming languages, making computers accessible beyond mathematicians.

- *Mary Anderson: Windshield Wiper (1903)* - She patented the first windshield wiper, now a standard feature in every automobile worldwide.

- *Josephine Cochrane: Dishwasher (1886)* - Her patented design reshaped household labor, creating the modern dishwasher and transforming domestic life.

Conclusion

The story of women in India's intellectual property landscape is not just about patents it is about possibility. Each filing, whether for a missile system, a lifesaving medical device, or a simple household innovation, represents courage, resilience, and a refusal to be sidelined.

For decades, women were underrepresented in innovation, held back by barriers of access, mentorship, and recognition. Today, they are steadily rewriting that narrative. From Tessy Thomas in defense labs to Geetha Manjunath in healthcare, from young Remya Jose's pedal-powered washing machine to Prerana Ratnaparkhi's everyday design solutions, women are proving that intellectual property is not an abstract legal tool it is a vehicle of empowerment and transformation.

India's IP revolution, with its surge in filings and rise in women-led innovation, signals a future where creativity knows no gender. The challenge ahead is to move from quantity to quality, ensuring that every patent filed becomes a solution that changes lives.

As more women step forward, they are not just protecting ideas they are reshaping industries, inspiring generations, and building a more inclusive innovation ecosystem. The quiet revolution is no longer quiet. It is the sound of women claiming their rightful place in India's story of progress.

Word Search Puzzle

PRIMER, CELL, CLONE, GENOME, VIRUS, CRISPR, GENE, PROTEIN, DNA, ENZYME

K	C	A	I	M	R	S	V	U	O
C	E	N	Z	Y	M	E	S	L	K
A	L	I	F	X	M	R	R	S	D
P	L	D	G	O	L	K	Q	U	N
O	A	A	N	I	E	T	O	R	P
D	R	E	N	O	L	C	P	I	U
I	G	S	S	D	C	S	G	V	Y
A	Q	P	P	R	I	M	E	R	G
S	P	H	T	R	D	L	N	O	K
M	J	X	C	M	N	A	E	C	Q

Riddles

- I am the recipe, the formula, or the list that makes you famous. I am not filed with the government, for if I am made public, I lose my power. I live in safe boxes and in the minds of few.

- I am a new invention, a better way to do things. I give you the exclusive right to make, use, or sell your creation, but only for a limited time. After that, I belong to everyone.

- I belong to you, but everyone else uses me more. If someone else starts using me to sell their goods, I can take them to court.

- I protect the song you sing, the book you write, and the art you create. I don't require a long registration process; I am born the moment your work is in a tangible form.

- I have no physical form, but I can be stolen. When I am taken, the original owner still has me, but they have lost their exclusive advantage.

- Two people invent the same machine on the same day. One rushes to the patent office, the other waits a week. Who wins?

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